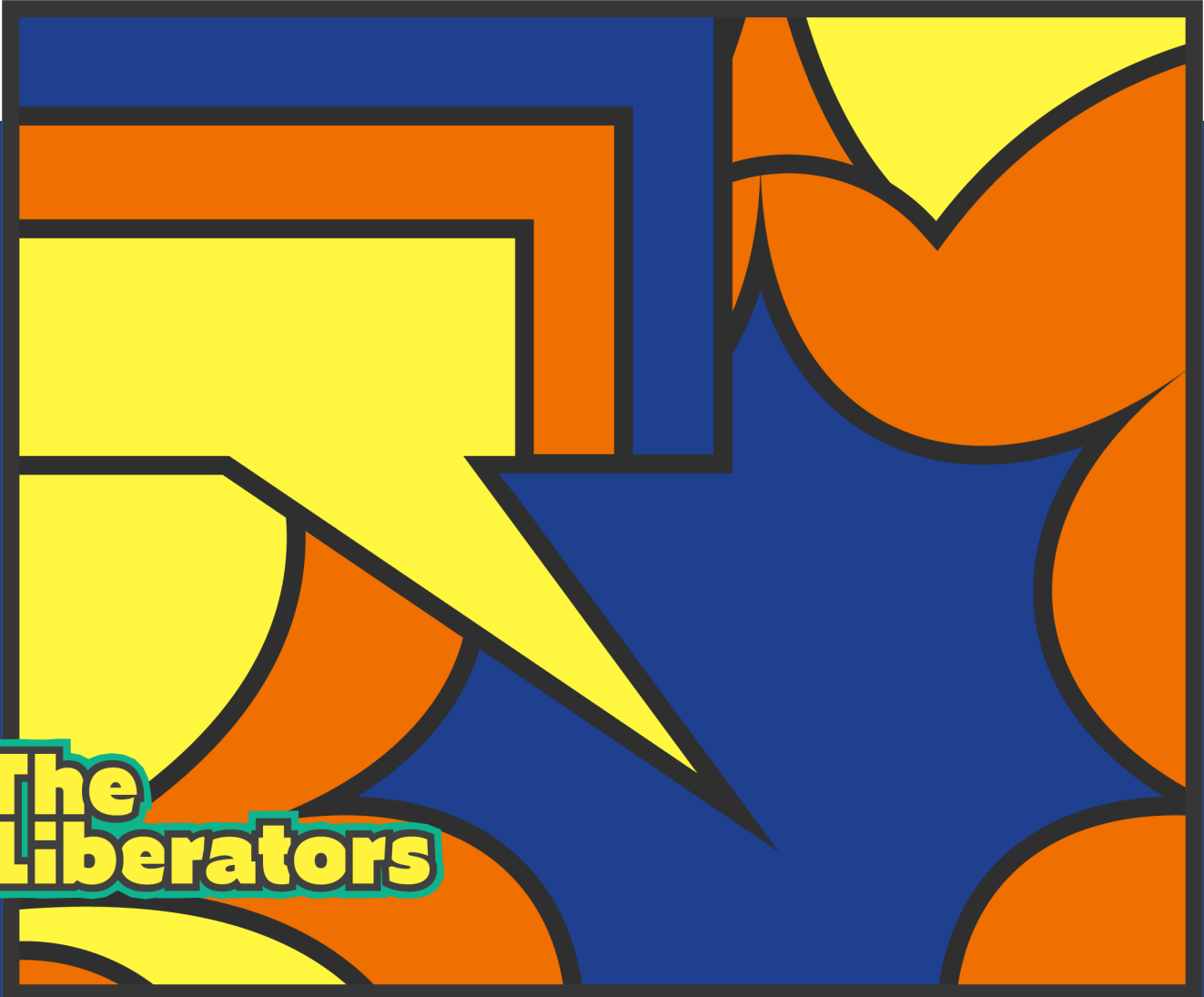


# Use Metrics To Purposefully Move Your Team Towards Its Ambitions

A do-it-yourself workshop to diagnose where your team is now, clarify its purpose and identify the path forward with "Strategy Knotworking"



**The  
Liberators**

# The Purpose Of This Workshop

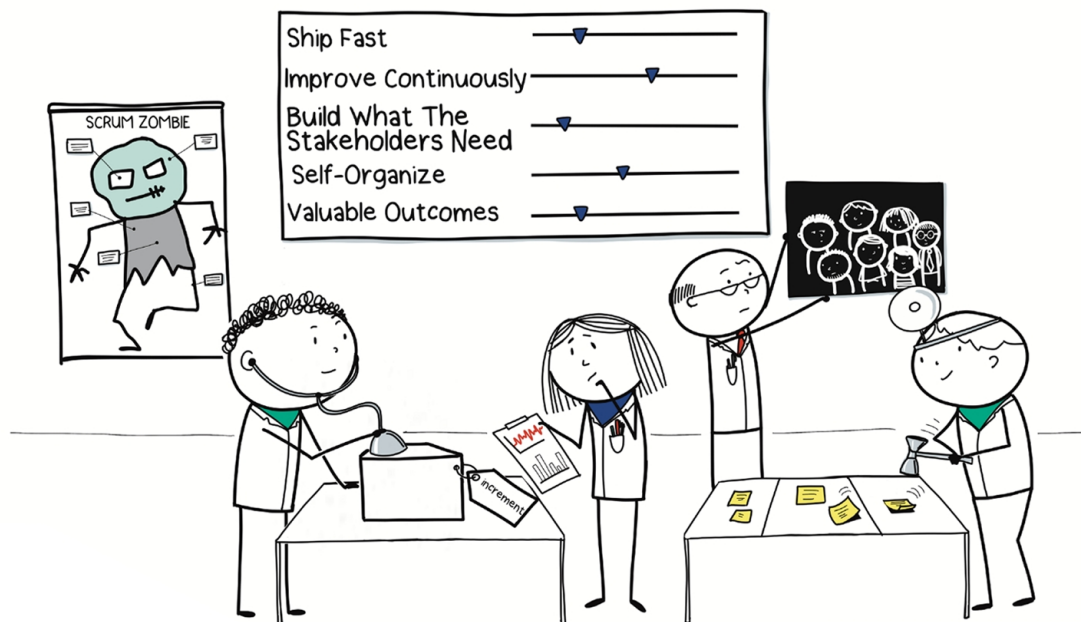
Hey there,

Improving is one thing. But how do the improvements match the purpose you have as a Scrum Team? What is your purpose? And how can you move in that direction to achieve it, and develop strategies to do so together? This is where Strategy Knotworking comes into play; a coherent set of Liberating Structures. We've found it to be a great approach to develop strategies with one or more teams and to do this periodically (every month or so) to purposefully work towards your ambitions together.

In this do-it-yourself workshop, we offer a simple and straightforward way to engage in Strategy Knotworking with your team. It draws in data from external metrics to drive the continuous improvement loop in your team, while also anchoring it into the purpose of your team.

*Barry & Christiaan*

## The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide  
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem  
[zombiescrum.org](http://zombiescrum.org)

# Flow

|                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Step 1: Opening</b>                                                        |  3 min                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of Your Team With 1-2-4-ALL</b>                |   20 min                                                                                     |
| <b>Step 3: Explore The Data</b>                                               |   15 min                                                                                     |
| <b>Step 4: Make Sense Of The Data Together With "What, So What, Now What"</b> |    45 min |
| <b>Step 5: Explore The Challenges With Conversation Cafe</b>                  |   35 min                                                                                     |
| <b>Step 6: Determine How To Measure Progress With 1-2-4-ALL</b>               |   20 min                                                                                     |
| <b>Step 7: Personal Next Steps</b>                                            |   10 min                                                                                   |
| <b>Step 8: Closing</b>                                                        |  2 min                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Total duration</b>                                                         |  150 min                                                                                                                                                                      |

# Difficulty / Effort

|                           |       |                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Required Skill</b>     | ☆☆☆☆☆ | Strategy Knotworking is about answering 6 core questions. The required skills depend on the Liberating Structures you select, you can make it as simple or complicated as you want. |
| <b>Impact On Survival</b> | ☆☆☆☆☆ | Creating a purpose statement isn't difficult. Achieving it is. This workshop helps you create it, inspect the progress, and make improvements, continuously.                        |



# How To Prepare



## Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum teams and stakeholders.

## Intended Audience

You can do this workshop with a single Scrum team, or with multiple Scrum teams working on the same product. It's also possible, maybe even recommended, to include your stakeholders and people from the supporting organization.

## Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

## Preparation

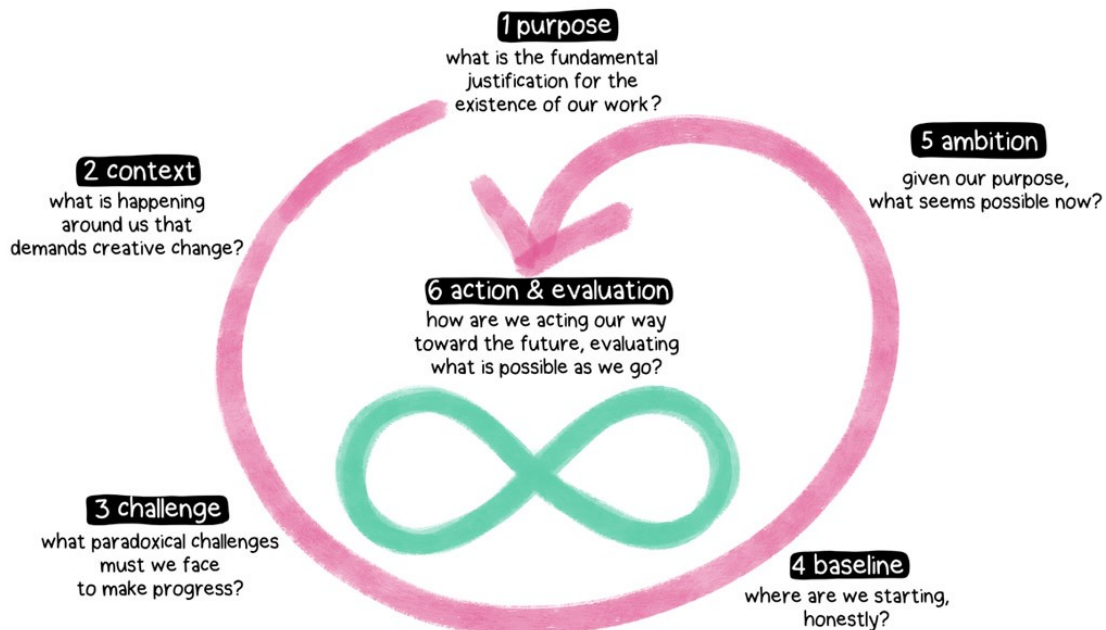
- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- We always find it helpful to have the 6 Strategy Knotworking questions available on a large (virtual) poster
- Collect the latest data from metrics that you use to evaluate your path forward. The [Scrum Team Survey](#) is a good source, but you can include other data like NPS scores, market conditions, or even financial results for your product or organization.

## Resources

- Whitepaper: [Liberating Strategy](#)
- Blog post [Strategy Knotworking: turning ideas and ambitions into reality](#)
- Blog post: [Strategy Knotworking – A Vital Skill to Quickly Respond to Change](#)
- A blog post that describes how we used Strategy Knotworking for The Liberators: [Moving Forward in a New and Uncertain World](#)



# Develop Improvement Strategies With Your Team With Strategy Knotworking



Created by Keith McCandless & Johannes Schartau

If an organization wants to work effectively with Scrum, they need a strategy. A strategy is essentially no more than a goal, followed by a series of actions required to achieve that goal as well as the players who need to be involved.

A goal could be to deliver more value to customers sooner. Or to decrease cycle time and lead time, improve team morale, or optimize return on investment. But this is still very vague. What does it mean? What are the success criteria? What would be good metrics to measure the progress? How do you know you've achieved it?

This is where Strategy Knotworking comes into play. Strategy Knotworking is a coherent set of Liberating Structures that aims to involve and engage everyone in developing and evolving sustainable strategies on all levels of an organization. It taps into everyone's experience, intelligence, and creativity while continuously (re)answering six core questions:

- **Purpose:** What is the fundamental justification for the existence of our work?
- **Context:** What is happening around us that demands creative change?
- **Challenges:** What paradoxical challenges must we face to make progress?
- **Baseline:** Where are we starting, honestly?
- **Ambition:** Given our purpose, what seems possible now?
- **Action & Evaluation:** How are we acting our way toward the future, evaluating what is possible as we go?

For a detailed description of Strategy Knotworking, read more about it in the paper [Liberating Strategy](#) by Keith McCandless and Johannes Schartau.

The strategy a Scrum team uses to achieve its purpose will always be unique and should be tailor-made to the team's environment, skills, and experience. As a result, the Liberating Structures you use to answer the six core questions can vary. In this do-it-yourself workshop, we share one approach, mostly focused on inspecting the outcome of the Scrum team survey and all other data that is relevant to evaluate the path forward.



## Step 1: Opening

Start the workshop by reiterating the purpose clearly and emphasize what will happen with the outcomes (and what won't). Make sure to emphasize that improvement is always a gradual, incremental, and often messy process and that this workshop is a step in that process.



## Step 2: Clarify The Purpose Of Your Team With 1-2-4-ALL

The first step of Strategy Knotworking is to clarify your purpose as a team. From there, you can develop strategies to move closer to your ambition. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) works well for this. It's an easy way to give all participants the opportunity to share their thoughts and to quickly notice important patterns.

### Invitation

"Looking back on our work from the future, what would need to happen for us or our stakeholders to say  
"Wow, this team did an incredible job there!"

### Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key insights in a shared workspace. If possible, try to formulate it as a one-liner "The purpose of our team is to..." or "The higher calling of our team is to ...". It's also fine to stick to a word-cloud and only discuss the key patterns that emerge.

### Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

### Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Make the Purpose of Your Work Together Clear with 'Nine Whys'](#)

## Step 3: Explore The Data

Now that you've created a shared understanding of the team's purpose, it's time to give everybody the opportunity to take in the data the team collected. For example, the results of the Scrum Team Survey, financial results, stakeholder happiness, cycle time, team morale, or information about market circumstances. Anything that is useful to inspect and will help identify the path forward.

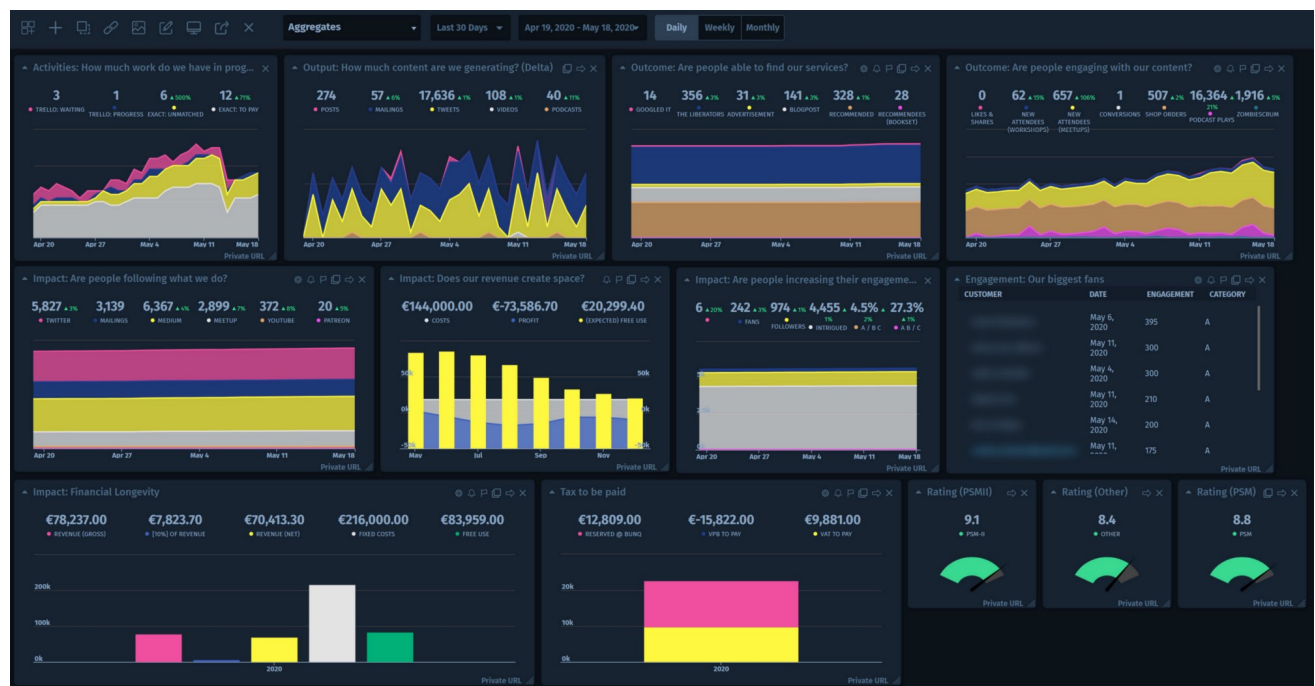
The image below is an example of some of the data we used for a similar Strategy Knotworking workshop for our own company, The Liberators. This data helped us make informed decisions on how to move forward. Such a data-driven approach is something we strongly recommend. Because if all you have to go on are assumptions, opinions, and intuitions, it's hard to be successful.

### Steps

- 1 min** Either hand out the printed data or ask people to walk around the room that you decorated with prints. If you're doing this virtually, share a [full-page screenshot](#) or print the entire page to a PDF.
- 9 min** Give everyone time to take in the data and encourage them to list questions, comments, or insights.

### Resources

- Blog post: [How We Use Metrics At The Liberators](#)



## Step 4: Make Sense Of The Data Together With "What, So What, Now What"



In this step, the team will dig deeper into the results of the survey, the metrics, and other data with the Liberating Structure "[What, So What, Now What](#)". This structure helps you make sense of the situation by breaking it down into three steps: "What do we notice?", "So, what does this mean?", "Now, what next steps make sense?". With "What, So What, Now What", we effectively cover the baseline, the context, and your ambitions.

### Invitation

Round 1: "Keeping our purpose as a team in mind, where are you surprised or delighted by our metrics?"

Round 2: "So, what does this mean for our work together as a team, and the ambitions we have? Where do we see a tension between where we want to be, and where we are now?"

Round 3: "Now, which challenges are the most impactful on our ability as a team to move forward at this moment in time?";

### Steps

#### Round 1: Observations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the first invitation. What do they notice? Encourage people to remain as factual as possible, taking the perspective of what an outsider would also notice about the data.
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share what they noticed. Encourage them to focus on

similarities and differences. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.

3. **10 min** Together, ask each group to share their most important observations and capture them in a workspace.

## Round 2: Interpretations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. What does this all mean about their work together? What do their observations say about this group?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their conclusions on what seems important. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **10 min** Together, ask each group to share their most important conclusions and capture them on a shared workspace.

## Round 3: Improvements

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the third invitation. Based on the conclusions from the second round, what makes sense now?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their suggestions for the adaptations that need to be made. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **15 min** Together, ask each group to share their most feasible adaptations and capture them on a shared workspace. Order them according to their impact.

## Resources

- If you run into tough impediments that partially lie outside your team, you can use this [Do-It-Yourself Workshop](#) to involve other teams and departments.
- If you run into impediments that are outside your control, you can mobilize more support with an [Impediment Newsletter](#)
- If you run into systemic impediments that are outside your control, you can also use this [Do-It-Yourself Workshop](#) to bring together people from different levels in your organization.
- Read [our post](#) on "What, So What, Now What", or read the [official post](#) from LiberatingStructures.com



## Step 5: Explore The Challenges With Conversation Cafe

With "What, So What, Now What" you diagnosed your current state, identified important challenges, and possible improvements that can help you realize your ambitions. In this round, we use the Liberating Structure [Conversation Café](#) to discuss what the team should change and improve in order to resolve the challenges and fulfill its ambition.

### Invitation

"Given our ambitions as a team, and the challenges we uncovered with 'What, So What, Now What', how would you propose we use our skills, resources, and autonomy to deliberately move forward?"

### Steps

1. If you do this in-person, ask people to form groups of 4 or 5 people. When done virtually, prepare breakouts.
2. **2 min** Share the invitation for Conversation Café and give everyone some time to individually and silently reflect.
3. **2 min** Provide a rough overview of the rounds. Each group goes through four rounds, two first rounds with a talking object, the third one as an open conversation, and a final round to share personal insights again.
4. **2 min** Explain that, once everyone is in their small groups, they will self-manage the rounds. Ask for each group to pick a host. The host is a full participant whose role is to keep the timeboxes and to gently intervene when a participant fails to observe the timebox or is talking on and on.
5. **5 min** In the first round, everyone shares their personal thoughts and experience with regard to the selected invitation. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
6. **5 min** In the second round, everyone shares thoughts and feelings after having listened to everybody. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
7. **8 min** The third round is an open and lively conversation.
8. **5 min** In the fourth round, everyone shares their takeaways from the conversation. People have the option to pass.
9. **5 min** Briefly discuss the patterns that emerged with the entire group.

### Our Findings

- It's helpful to keep the visual with all the steps visible while everyone is in the breakout rooms. You can prepare a Mural or Google Presentation that contains all the steps.
- Emphasize that groups should use talking objects. Participants can use whatever they prefer as a talking object, as long as they have one. A pen or marker that participants "pass around" is a fun way of using a talking object online. A good practice is that the person holding the talking object decides who goes next.
- Encourage people to really listen. In the first two rounds and in the final round, the purpose is not to have a discussion, to ask each other questions, or to start a conversation. The purpose is only for each participant to share their perspectives while the others offer their full attention.

### Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Conversation Cafe



# Conversation Café

## We agree to ...

1. Suspend judgement
2. Respect one another
3. Seek to understand rather than persuade
4. Invite and honor diverse opinions
5. Speak what has personal heart and meaning
6. Go for honesty and depth without going on and on and on and on ...

Decide who volunteers as a host. The host fully participates, and gently intervenes where necessary to protect the agreements and timeboxes.

1

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and thoughts on the topic. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

2

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and observations on the first round. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

3

As a group, engage in open, lively conversation about the topic. If you want, you can continue to use the talking object (10-30 min).

4

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their takeaways from the conversation. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who goes next. People may skip a turn.



Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz.

[shop.theliberators.com](http://shop.theliberators.com)





## Step 6: Determine How To Measure Progress With 1-2-4-ALL

In the previous step, you used Conversation Cafe to discuss the ideas and strategies to help you deal with the challenges you must face. In this step, you'll define the success criteria by which you can track the progress you make in dealing with the challenges. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly involve & engage all participants in sharing ideas.

### Invitation

"Now that we're here, how can we evaluate our progress forward?"

### Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down examples that come to mind.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Debrief together and collect the key insights in a shared workspace.

### Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



## Step 7: Personal Next Steps

We always close by asking people to write down a personal next step. This way, everyone can contribute to the solution in whatever way is possible for them. Many small steps together easily accumulate to large change.

### Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to our Strategy Knotworking? What is something, or a next step, you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"

### Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

### Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

### Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

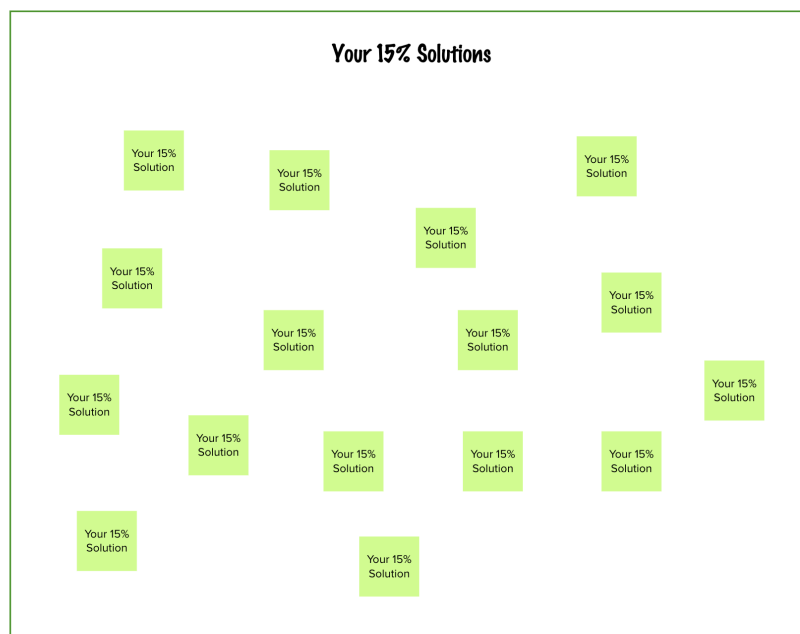
#### Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

#### Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



## Step 8: Closing

With this exercise, you create transparency around where you are as a team. We highly recommend that you revisit the metrics and success criteria you identified periodically, and create transparency around how your team is developing. Rinse and repeat is what makes Strategy Knotworking powerful.

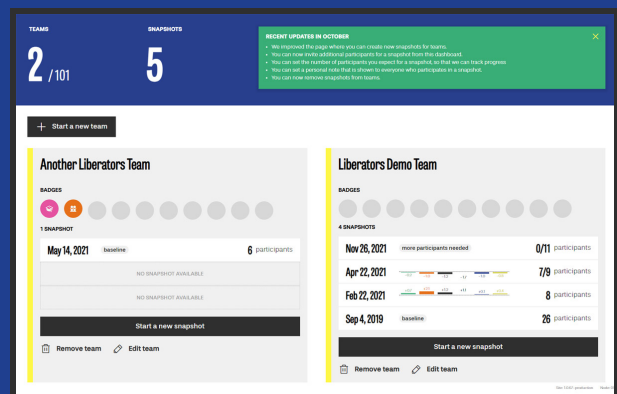
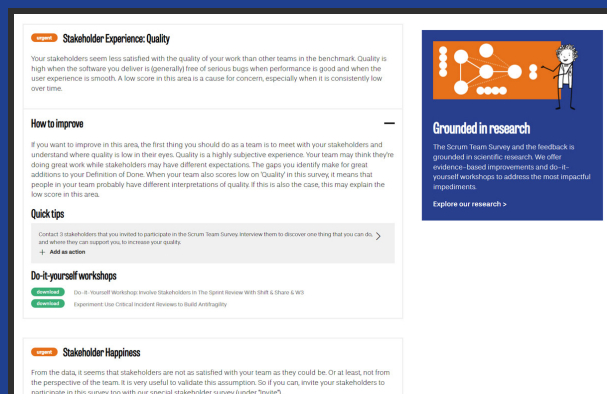
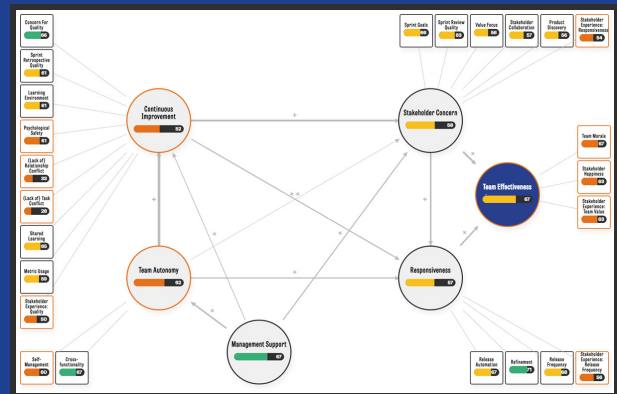
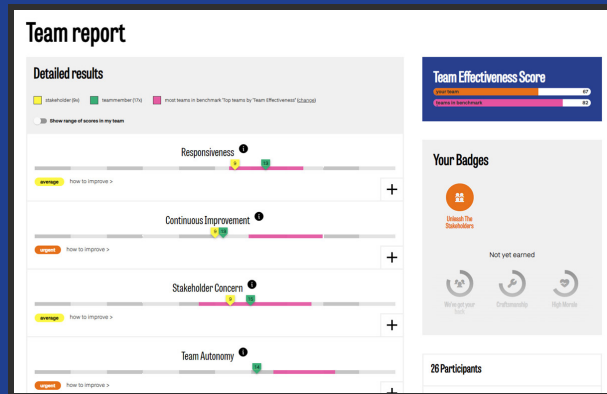
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



# Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



|                                                         | Essential  | Liberator   |
|---------------------------------------------------------|------------|-------------|
| Invite team members & stakeholders                      | unlimited  | unlimited   |
| Quick Tips for your team per topic                      | 3          | unlimited   |
| Recommendations to your team                            | 5          | unlimited   |
| Compare your team against different benchmarks          |            | ✓           |
| Analyze the range of scores in your team                |            | ✓           |
| Receive our personal guidance on how to get started     |            | ✓           |
| See where your team improves over time with Team Trends |            | ✓           |
| Support our academic research to help more teams        |            | ✓           |
| <b>Pricing per team per month</b>                       | <b>€ 0</b> | <b>€ 10</b> |

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

[info@scrumteamsurvey.org](mailto:info@scrumteamsurvey.org)

# Unleashing Teams All Over The World

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